

Chicago Tribune



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'Caught in the middle'

Keeping federal agents in check still a challenge one year after Operation Midway Blitz launched

By Madeline Buckley, Caroline Kubzansky, Dan Petrella and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A Schaumburg police officer responded to a 911 call in June from a federal immigration agent who reported being followed, then turned off his body camera at the agent's request.

A Forest Park parking enforcement worker moved a federal agent's car in July while police leaders let the agent slip out the back of the village police station, where he'd ducked in to avoid an activist's camera.

An Evanston police commander defended his officers' response to the mayor in October after immigration agents drove away from a violent confrontation with residents on a north suburban street.

These incidents and many others like them underscore how — a year after President Donald Trump launched Operation Midway Blitz — quick, chaotic encounters involving immigration authorities, local police and Chicago-area residents continue to leave the public and elected officials alike grasping for answers and seeking accountability.

During and after the immigration crackdown, which amounted to a

small-scale military incursion into Chicago and its suburbs, local officials have been beset by disagreements and hand-wringing over how to meet the moment, according to dozens of Tribune interviews and a review of hundreds of pages of documents obtained through public records requests.

The blitz was the most dramatic test to date of the rules of engagement Illinois has established for how local law enforcement deals with federal immigration agents. In the months since, the Tribune found, those rules have grown no clearer.

Local police and other officials "were not prepared for the type of blitz that came in," said Rubén



A U.S. Border Patrol agent reaches over Chicago police officers while threatening to use a canister against protesters in Brighton Park on Oct. 4, 2025. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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GREAT WASTE IN THE GREAT LAKES



THE OVERWHELMING PROBLEM OF PLASTIC

From flax that can be used in clothing and cars, to robotic skimmers, to stricter laws, researchers, activists, volunteers fight an industry intent on making more of the material

By Michael Hawthorne | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Spending more than a decade documenting the spread of plastic waste throughout the Great Lakes took a psychological toll on Melissa Duhaime.

Scary findings. Seemingly few solutions to intractable problems. Scientists stacked against the world's most clout-heavy corporations bent on tripling production of fossil fuel-based plastics.

Duhaime, a University of Michigan biologist, found solace — and maybe a chance to build her own business while bolstering the regional economy — in a plastics-free alternative dating back to ancient Mesopotamia, now known as Iraq.

She decided to adjust her research and focus on flax, a plant that can be spun into linen and woven into clothing instead of polyester, acrylic or other synthetic fabrics that shed plastic fibers every time they are laundered.

The stems of flax, mostly grown in America these days for versatile, nutritious seeds, also are a proven substitute for petroleum-based carbon fiber in automobiles and construction.

"Our farmers are interested, some big companies are interested," Duhaime said in a recent interview. "We have the potential to create a new manufacturing sector when it comes to the growing and processing of (flax) fibers, spinning and weaving them, and developing new products."

Duhaime is among a cadre of researchers, environmental activists, policymakers and volunteers striving to curb the onslaught of plastics in every aspect of life.

Some focus on legislation in state capitals and city councils and push for a global treaty that would limit plastics production.

Innovators seek to swap plastics for sustainable options and develop new methods to skim plastic litter out of the environment.

Beach cleanups draw attention to a throwaway culture spawned and encour-

Reporting for this story was supported by the Pulitzer Center's StoryReach U.S. initiative.

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Above: Melissa Duhaime, center, an associate professor at the University of Michigan, hand-processes recently harvested flax straw to prepare fibers for engineering experiments with farmer Kyle Thom, left, and graduate student Shiho Apperson, on Tuesday at her home farm in Dexter, Michigan. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

If 7-OH is banned, many may seek care

Addiction recovery providers brace for influx of new patients

By Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Many Illinois residents have likely never heard of 7-OH, even though a federal official has warned that the substance — often sold in tablet, liquid and gummy form in vape shops and convenience stores — could drive the next wave of the opioid epidemic.

Now, a federal proposal that would ban 7-OH has sent Illinois business owners scrambling to clear it from their shelves, and led some addiction recovery providers to brace themselves for an influx of new patients if 7-OH products are no longer available.

"We've seen a threefold increase in new patients due to 7-OH," in recent weeks, said Dr. David Kushner, medical director at Brightside Recovery, a substance use disorder treatment provider headquartered in Northbrook. "It's been dramatic."

The compound 7-OH, short for 7-hydroxymitragynine, is found in very small amounts in the kratom plant. But in recent years, companies have started selling tablets, gummies and liquids containing artificially high concentrations of 7-OH, which acts like an opioid on the body.

Over the summer, the U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration proposed temporarily adding products containing elevated levels of 7-OH to its list of Schedule I substances — a designation reserved for drugs with no acceptable medical use and a high potential for abuse, such as LSD and heroin. The move would make 7-OH products illegal.

A comment period related to the proposed change ended Sept. 10, and it's unclear if or when the change might be finalized. A DEA spokesperson said in a recent email that it's "still in process, and we do not have anything to report in respect to a timeline."

If the change goes into effect, an order could be issued placing 7-OH on Schedule I for up to two years, according to the U.S. Food and Drug Administration.

But Illinois businesses selling the product haven't waited for a final decision to take action.

One Chicago-area vape shop owner, who asked not to be named

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Postseason on the horizon

The Cubs extend their reign of chaos with a relocated finale in Florida and playoff seed at stake. Plus, how the Sox defied history. **Sports**



Aglow once again

After a prolonged dormant period, the weather bell on the Rector Building in the Loop is now repaired and restored. **Arts & Entertainment**

Heavy rain batters Northeast

A slow-moving, powerful storm crept along the Northeast, producing high winds, heavy rains and flooding. **Nation & World, Page B5**

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